

Next morning, Utgarda-Loki told Thor his secret. “I’ve been using magic to trick you,” he said. “You remember Skrymir? That was me. The knot in my bag you couldn’t undo was made of iron. And I only survived those three hammer blows by deflecting them with sorcery.”

Thor gaped as Utgarda-Loki continued: “Loki’s opponent was no giant, but fire, which consumes everything. Thjalfi raced against thought, which no one can outpace. Your drinking horn was connected to the sea, which you nearly drained. The cat was the World Serpent, Jörmungandr, which you actually lifted into the sky.”

“And the woman who threw me about?”

“Old age, which beats everyone.”

Before a furious Thor could raise Mjölfnir to strike, Utgarda-Loki and his castle disappeared.

